

Giulia Ferrero

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Research interests

Primary Political Economy, Economic History and Development
Secondary Narratives, Media, Conflict, Gender

Current position

Visiting PhD Student <i>forthcoming!</i> <i>ENS Lyon - CERGIC</i> Sponsor: Mathieu Couttenier	Summer 2026 Lyon, France
Visiting PhD Student <i>forthcoming!</i> <i>UCLA Anderson</i> Sponsor: Nico Voigtlander	May 2026 Los Angeles, USA
CID PhD Fellow, Harvard Kennedy School <i>Center for International Development - Harvard Kennedy School</i> Sponsor: Eliana La Ferrara	Spring 2026 Boston, USA
PhD Candidate in Economics, Università di Torino and Collegio Carlo Alberto <i>Doctoral Fellow at Collegio Carlo Alberto</i> Advisors: Elena Esposito and Giovanni Mastrobuoni	2022 - Present Torino, Italy

Education

Second Cycle Master Degree in Economics (LMEC) <i>Alma Mater Studiorum - Università di Bologna</i> - Final Grade: 110 cum laude Supervisors: Matteo Cervellati and Paolo Vanin Master Thesis: “Organized Violence in a global perspective: an empirical investigation, 1989-2019”	2018 – 2020 Bologna, Italy
Bachelor in Economics <i>University of Torino</i> - Final Grade: 110 cum laude	2015 - 2018 Torino, Italy
Complex Network Analysis: Tools for Economic Development <i>Barcelona School of Economics (BSE)</i>	July 2023 Barcelona, Spain

Working Papers

Wartime Narratives and Gender Norms (JMP)
Awarded the 2025 Mixtape Fellowship by Scott Cunningham

Governments have long used mass media narratives as a policy tool to shape social norms and behavior, yet causal evidence on the effects of such interventions remains scarce. This paper studies the case of the U.S. government’s coordinated media campaigns during World War II, which deliberately reshaped the public image of women to address wartime labor shortages. I construct a new dataset combining historical newspapers with a newly digitized archive of women’s magazines, which allows to trace changes in representations of women before, during, and after the war. Exploiting local variation in war-induced labor shortages and using an event-study design, I document a pronounced wartime shift toward portraying women as workers, followed by a rapid reversal once the war ended. While this narrative was short-lived, areas more exposed to wartime pressures experienced a persistent increase in the visibility of women in public discourse. To isolate the causal effect of media narratives from local labor market conditions, I combine historical survey data with a shift-share strategy based on magazine circulation and national changes in content. Exposure to wartime narratives significantly shaped postwar attitudes toward women’s roles and political participation, with effects that outlasted the economic shock itself. The results suggest that institutional messaging can rapidly reshape social narratives, even in non-authoritarian settings, with unintended consequences that may persist beyond the original shock.

Sons of War: the Effect of Conflict on Son Preference with Jessica Mancuso
Awarded the Grigor Artsruni Award at the Armenian Economic Association Conference in Yerevan

Armenia and Azerbaijan, engaged in the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict, are known for their strong son preference and widespread use of abortion. In such a peculiar setting, we ask: does ethnic conflict affect son preference? By merging Demographic and Health Survey (DHS) data with two different sources of conflict-related casualties, we investigate the effect of ethnic conflict on fertility decisions. To do so, we leverage variations in geographic and temporal exposure to conflict-related violence in the context of the First Nagorno-Karabakh War (1988–1994), alongside variation in the gender composition of children between families. We find that families with only daughters exposed to conflict increase their

fertility in the very short term. Furthermore, our analysis of births by gender reveals that this result is driven by the birth of sons. Conflict intensifies son preference, manifesting in son-targeted fertility behavior and sex-selective abortions. Lastly, we identify child replacement as a mechanism contributing to the increase in fertility, driven primarily by the replacement of male children.

Work in Progress

Narratives and Movies with Elena Esposito, Tiziano Rotesi and Alessandro Saia

Conference and seminar presentations

- 2026 Alberto Alesina Graduate Student Workshop in Political Economy and Culture at Harvard University, 11th MPWZ-CEPR Text-As-Data Workshop, ESP Workshop at the Harvard Kennedy School, Graduate Workshop in Economic History - Harvard University, CID Research Xchange at Harvard Kennedy School
- 2025 2025 BAEM (Bristol Applied Economics Meetings) Workshop on Gender, Diversity and Human Capital, Fragile Lives 2025, VPDE 2025 internal PhD forum, Third Political Economy CCA-Cornell-Bocconi Winter Workshop (poster)
- 2024 VPDE 2024 internal PhD forum

Teaching

Econometric Theory I - graduate 2023-2025
Collegio Carlo Alberto - TA to Yagan Hazard

Microeconomics Spring 2024
SAA - School of Management TA to Nadia Campaniello

Professional Experience

Research Assistant for Elena Esposito (*CCA/UNITO*) 2023
Research Assistant for Margherita Fort and Michela Carlana (*UNIBO*) 2022
Trainee in DGI - External Developments (DG-I/EXT) - European central bank (*ECB*) 2021-2022
Research Assistant for Matteo Cervellati (*UNIBO*) 2020
Research Assistant for Luca Lambertini (*UNIBO*) 2019

Skills

IT knowledge Python, STATA, R, Latex, Qualtrics, QGIS, text analysis, web scraping, LLMs - assistants management and validation

Languages Italian (mother tongue); English (fluent)

References

Elena Esposito Collegio Carlo Alberto, Junior Chair Full professor in Economics ESOMAS, Department of Economics University of Torino e.esposito@unito.it	Giovanni Mastrobuoni Collegio Carlo Alberto, Carlo Alberto Chair Full professor in Economics ESOMAS, Department of Economics University of Torino giovanni.mastrobuoni@carloalberto.org
Scott Cunningham Ben H. Williams Professor of Economics Baylor University	Juan Vargas Collegio Carlo Alberto, Carlo Alberto Chair Full professor in Economics ESOMAS, Department of Economics University of Torino juan.vargas@carloalberto.org

May 14, 2026